

PRIZED SCALP: Brian Lara, of the Mumbai Champs, is dismissed first ball by the Hyderabad Heroes



A League of Their Own

For the first time ever, a cricket event in India goes ahead, despite disapproval from the BCCI. The ICL masters cricket logistics but the real test will be to win TV audiences and the market.

■ By Sharda Ugra

You could laugh at the Indian Cricket (ICL) League for being launched in a stadium named after a politician not known for statesmanship, in an unfashionable corner of Chandigarh called Panchkula. Or laugh because its stellar attraction Brian Lara looked like a bad investment every time he stepped out to the crease.

But you could not laugh at the fact that it was launched at all, without a hair out of place.

After months of speculation that suggested that something like the ICL could not possibly be done, or conceivably be worth it, the 'rebel' league had actually set out its stall. The inaugu-

ral ICL, promoted by the Essel Group, was held, as promised, as a Twenty20 event between six city teams lasting 16 days from start to finish. It was pitched as an event to showcase domestic talent which would get a chance to train

REBEL CRICKET: Six teams lined up in Chandigarh for the first ICL

and play with former international players like Lara. One of the ICL's tacit intentions was, of course, to make the BCCI's handling and promotion of domestic cricket, look bad.

Not difficult at all. In April 2007, the BCCI held its Inter-State Twenty20 Tournament on an 'experimental'

basis all across the country. It caused no buzz, the BCCI did not sell television rights for it, and even with players like Yuvraj Singh, Robin Uthappa, Dinesh Karthick involved, all grounds were near empty.

When the Chandigarh Lions played the Delhi Jets in the first ICL match in Panchkula, the 7,000-seater Tau Devi Lal Stadium was packed for its first weekend, ringed by advertising boards



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